

Chapter 78_1 - Heartache

Everyone present looked toward her. While Ning Fuyi felt puzzled, she also finally breathed a sigh of relief as she watched Jiang Li get up and walk outside with Chu Qingqiu.

She looked toward Mo Qihuai, who was also looking at her with a smile. Ning Fuyi hurriedly averted her gaze, calming the unease in her heart.

In the courtyard, tree shadows swayed and wind swept up fallen leaves. For a moment, even Cloud Ascension Mountain seemed to have hints of autumn.

Jiang Li smiled as she followed Chu Qingqiu. Only after ensuring Ning Fuyi couldn't hear them did Chu Qingqiu stop, turning around in the dawn light to look at Jiang Li.

"You don't need to deliberately provoke me," she said.

"Divine Venerable thinks too much. I was merely giving them instructions," Jiang Li said with a gentle smile. "However, the young sect leader seems quite resistant. I think it's still necessary to let them spend more time together to cultivate their feelings..."

"There's no need to cultivate anything," Chu Qingqiu closed her eyes. Her face was still pale, and if one looked carefully, they could see that her lips had been bitten until they bled.

Jiang Li tilted her head, making a questioning sound.

Chu Qingqiu suddenly extended her right hand, her left hand gently stroking over it. Scattered feathers dispersed, and on her originally clean pale fingers, a red cord appeared.

"This is..." Jiang Li moved closer to look, immediately shocked. "This is, a marriage contract!?"

"How could Divine Venerable have a marriage contract? Who is it with? Could it be..."

Jiang Li today had probably heard the biggest gossip she'd ever heard. Her beautiful eyes widened as she looked toward the wooden house behind them.

"The, the young sect leader?"

Chu Qingqiu didn't answer, only lowered her hand to hide the red cord, which was as good as confirmation.

Jiang Li was so surprised she couldn't speak for a long time. After digesting this for a while, she finally covered her lips and said, "Divine Venerable telling me such a secret, you're not planning to silence me after everything is done, are you?"

"Medical Immortal¹ is overthinking."

"I'm telling you so much because I trust you. Since I trust you, I won't do anything to you." Chu Qingqiu said, secretly stroking the place where the red cord had disappeared.

Hearing this, Jiang Li patted her chest: "Then this marriage contract of Divine Venerable's presumably isn't truly for marriage, but because of the demonic tree inside the young sect leader?"

"Marriage contracts can only be formed between cultivators. Once the contract is made, their fates become one. If one party falls into demonhood, the other will suffer backlash." Jiang Li shook her head. "It seems Divine Venerable has long worried that the young sect leader would fall into demonhood, even going so far as to risk suffering backlash yourself to prevent it."

"Yes, but I didn't know there would be a demonic tree in her sea of consciousness," Chu Qingqiu lowered her eyes.

Jiang Li didn't ask more questions. She observed Chu Qingqiu's expression and said softly, "So Divine Venerable called me out to show me the marriage contract because you want to say about dual cultivation..."

"Can I be the one to do it?" Chu Qingqiu raised her eyes.

Several withered leaves flew past the two of them, carried away by the wind down the mountain, disappearing without a trace.

"The matter in her sea of consciousness cannot be known by anyone else, and I'm familiar with her. With the marriage contract binding us, our divine consciousnesses will merge faster than with others..." Chu Qingqiu began to explain.

But Jiang Li seemed to have already heard the subtext in her words, only looking at her knowingly. Finally, Chu Qingqiu stopped speaking and turned away.

Jiang Li smiled, her expression truly helpless.

"Divine Venerable, oh Divine Venerable, with such a temperament, no wonder you've been lonely for a thousand years."

"However, Divine Venerable truly is the best choice," she said.

Mo Qihuai exchanged a few words with Ning Fuyi, then quickly took her leave, saying she invited her to meet at the Moon Viewing Terrace on the mountaintop tonight at the hour of the boar².

After she left, Ning Fuyi pushed open the door to look toward the distance, but there were no longer any traces of Chu Qingqiu and Jiang Li there, only empty autumn wind.

Disappointment crossed her heart, and she forcefully closed the door behind her.

A snapping sound reached her ears. Jiuying had returned at some point and was sitting on the table, holding two roasted chickens in her hands, throwing one to Ning Fuyi.

"What are you upset about?" she said.

"I'm not upset," Ning Fuyi replied indifferently. She reached out to catch the roasted chicken and set it aside. "Where's Ping An³?"

"Let it play by itself. The way it looks, if it doesn't lose weight soon, it won't be able to walk," Jiuying used her fingertip to tear off a piece of roasted chicken and put it in her mouth. While eating with satisfaction, she observed Ning Fuyi's expression.

"You say you're not upset, but your mouth is almost pouting like the character 'eight.' Isn't it because of Divine Venerable?"

"No, I just can't understand why I feel suffocated," Ning Fuyi sat down silently and drank all the tea on the table in one gulp.

"That's still being suffocated because of Divine Venerable," Jiuying said decisively. She hooked her finger, and the teacup in front of Ning Fuyi filled up again.

Ning Fuyi drank it dry in one gulp again, then suddenly looked up and asked Jiuying, "If you had someone you cared about, would you be willing to let her be intimate with someone else?"

"Me?" Jiuying scoffed. "How could there be anyone in this world that I, Qi Jiuying, would care about."

"However, any normal person wouldn't be happy seeing the one they love with someone else," Jiuying said. She jumped down from the table and walked in front of Ning Fuyi.

"I feel the same way, so I'm now thinking that what you said that day was probably wrong," Ning Fuyi gazed deeply at the cracked glaze cup in front of her, her fingers suddenly applying force, actually crushing the cup along its cracks.

"Which things?" This time it was Jiuying's turn to be surprised.

"You said she treats me differently," Ning Fuyi threw away the fragments in her palm and patted her clothes as she stood up. "I'm going to find Wenzhu⁴ to cultivate. You rest."

With that, her figure flashed and disappeared, leaving behind the bewildered Jiuying, who shook her head and picked up the roasted chicken again.

"Humans always love to guess back and forth, going in circles," she moved her hair behind her ear and took a big bite.

Ning Fuyi's cultivation was also absent-minded. During sparring with Liu Wenzhu, she almost had her head smashed by the thousand-jin hammer⁵. In the end, Liu Wenzhu really didn't dare to practice with her anymore and simply replaced the thousand-jin hammer with a tree branch before exchanging a few more moves with Ning Fuyi.

Footnotes:

¹ **Medical Immortal (医仙)** - A title referring to someone who has achieved immortal-level mastery in medicine and healing arts

² **Hour of the boar (亥时)** - The time period from 9-11 PM in the traditional Chinese timekeeping system

³ **Ping An (平安)** - A name meaning "peace" or "safety," likely referring to a pet or companion animal

⁴ **Wenzhu (文竹)** - Liu Wenzhu's given name, showing their close friendship through the informal address

⁵ **Thousand-jin hammer (千斤锤)** - A very heavy training weapon; a jin is approximately 0.5 kg, so this would be around 500 kg